

Buffalo WHR-HP-AG108 “Air Station”

Great show with the go!

The AG108 exemplifies build quality. It's a great looker, and that grey-and-silver body will look smart on your desk, and equally so atop your bedroom armoire! It sported the biggest (physically) antenna we've seen on a Wi-Fi router. It was also the only router we received with 802.11a compliance. This means the AG108 can simultaneously create a 5 GHz (802.11a) and a 2.4 GHz network (802.11b/g). It even utilises a technique Buffalo calls “Channel Bonding” to increase throughput by clubbing the available bandwidth (of both the 5 and 2.4 GHz networks) together.

The device sports an AOSS button (Air station

One-touch Secure System). Very simply, this button automatically assigns WPA keys to all clients on the wireless network, once you've installed the software on each of them. You'll also have to click the Profiles tab. Incidentally, the AG108 has a good firmware interface, and is easy to navigate even for first time users.

The AG108 performed decently in all the tests, save one—our video streaming test—where, for some reason, we got some framing.

The Air Station AG108 is a good product with a lot of add-on features, but there other products available that outperform it on all fronts.



Compex NetPassage 27G

Ultraconnectivity!

With four RJ45 (LAN) ports in addition to two USB ports, connectivity is never going to be a bottleneck with the NP-27G. It has an inbuilt print server, making it ideal for the SoHo segment.

The NP27G incorporates the Atheros XR (eXtended Range) technology, which improves coverage area of a Wi-Fi network, eliminating dead spots. Atheros XR also supports a stronger signal than what 802.11 specifications imply, and supports additional data transfer rates.

The software interface on the NP27G firmware was the best we've seen this time round. It's very

intuitive, and each option is properly placed under a relevant sub-category.

Configuring the NP27G was very easy via the interface, and even a newbie shouldn't have too many problems during the setup.

Though the NP27G's transfer rates weren't the slowest in our tests, it was very close to the bottom. Surprisingly, it fared decently in the movie streaming test: although the video was jerky at times, it wasn't as bad as we'd expected. The NP27G loses out on performance but scores on features. It is reasonably priced at Rs 5,500.



Compex NetPassage 28G

Feature-laden—but light on performance!

With three LAN ports and four USB ports, the NP 28G is primarily aimed at the SoHo segment. Home users will also benefit, especially if you want to hook up a printer or even a Web camera (courtesy the extra USB ports). Atheros' XR makes another appearance here. The firmware is identical to that of the excellent NP-27G.

The NP 28G is slightly slower than the NP27G, but only by a hairsbreadth! They perform similarly when the AP is in the client's vicinity. Once the

distance increases—and signal attenuation occurs—we see the NP 27G creeping ahead.

This shows that the NP 28G is less suitable for heavy bandwidth inter-room usage. The streaming test also did not complet to our satisfaction, and there was noticeable framing.

Overall, a good feature set at an outrageous price—Rs 8,500—especially considering its less-than-ideal performance.



Level One WAP-0010

A decent performer

The WAP 0010 is a funky looker with a sober grey body, getting a slash of silver in the form of its logo embossed topside. With three antennas and MIMO support, we had high hopes for this product in our test.

Coming to the firmware, there's no username field; you need to type in a password in the field titled “login”. We found all the settings under appropriate heads, and most of the deeper settings were transparent, allowing us to tweak them to our

heart's content.

Unfortunately, no amount of tweaking helped it perform well! To compare it to the proverbial tortoise would be unfair, as there were slower competitors in the test. Needless to say, if you're looking at bandwidth-hungry data transfers and movie streaming, give the WAP-0010 a wide berth.

